

QED | SHANKAR AIYAR

Audacity of Pretense

In July this year, a helicopter with four crew members disappeared over the forests in Chhattisgarh. There are two scenarios: either the copter was shot down, or worse, that it is in the possession of Naxalites. You could argue this is a potentially serious issue for internal security but 116 days after the incident, only the pilot's family is pursuing the matter. Neither the state nor the Centre is in any great rush to probe and conclude the matter. Neither national security nor the plaintive cries of a lonely family can change that.

Last week Indians were shocked to learn about the involvement of a serving army officer with a terror outfit. How did we get here? The answer is: criminal somnolence. It is no secret that India has been the target of the largest number of terror attacks after Iraq and Afghanistan. The crisis requires a cogent response from the security establishment and a consensual approach from the political class. What we get instead is botched-up investigations and a political response that can only be described as opportunistic.

In Mumbai, lumpen elements in the quest for power are violating the most fundamental of rights—the right of an Indian to live and work in any part of India. As if this wasn't bad, vigilante mobs in Haryana and Bihar are targeting people and public property. Yet, the state is unwilling to apply the rule of law. Justice, Liberty, Equality and Fraternity have been reduced to words entombed in a scroll now being torn asunder. And why are the national political parties silent? Is it because a new stir-fried morality among voters allows parties to adopt divisive means for a political end?

Look around. Governments across the world are scrambling to put their economies in order. Obama is talking of a new deal, Japan has a 27-trillion yen programme. Even totalitarian China worried about the political fallout and has put together a \$586-billion stimulus package. All

that we have seen in terms of action is easing of liquidity, that too by the RBI. Neither the loss of jobs or destruction of wealth has stirred the political mindscape. Not yet.

You could ask how the political class can afford the blissful pretense of stability when the India Story—social and economic—seems to be coming apart. Yes they can, because India's derivatives democracy allows the political class to leverage fractional support to acquire power. So it is not only okay but profitable to pander to narrow interests rather than the national spectrum. Yes they can, because "we the people" are cocooned in an audacious pretense that democracy needs no participation, that it is a spectator sport.



SELECTED: ISRO chairman **G. Madhavan Nair**, for this year's K.R. Narayanan award for his contributions to science and for



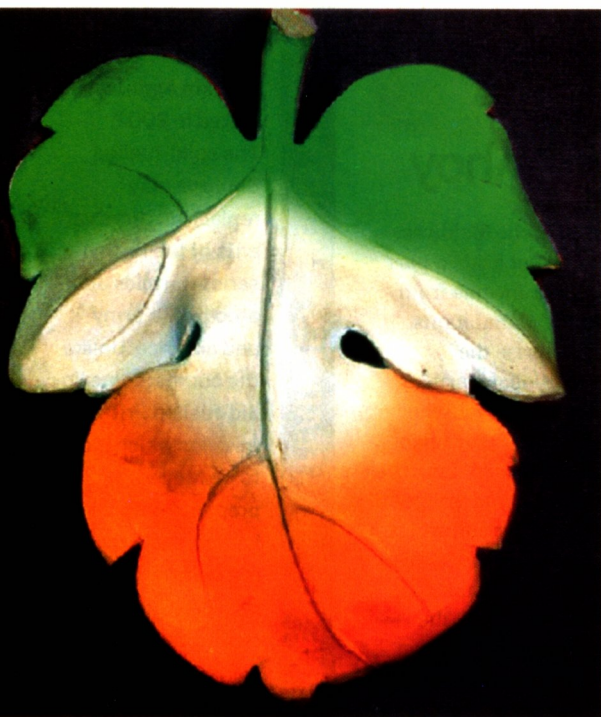
Chandrayaan-1, India's first unmanned mission to the moon.

ESTABLISHED: By Saurashtra's **Cheteshwar Pujara** and **Ravindra Jadeja**, a world record for the highest partnership in first class cricket—an unbeaten 520 against Orissa in a Ranji Trophy match.

SENTENCED: CPI(M)'s former Singur zonal committee secretary **Suhridd Datta** to life imprisonment for the murder of anti-land acquisition activist **Tapasi Malik** in 2006, by a local court.



NAMED: Pepsico chief **Indra Nooyi** (below), Cisco's **Padmasree Warrior** and INX Media's Chief Executive **Indrani Mukherjea** in *The Wall Street Journal's* global list of 50 Women To Watch For.



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